

THE PURPOSE OF THE CHURCH

TEXT: Luke 19:45-48

(NKJV) *“Then He went into the temple and began to drive out those who bought and sold in it,⁴⁶ saying to them, **“It is written, ‘My house is a house of prayer,’ but you have made it a ‘den of thieves.’**”⁴⁷ And He was teaching daily in the temple. But the chief priests, the scribes, and the leaders of the people sought to destroy Him,⁴⁸ and were unable to do anything; for all the people were very attentive to hear Him.”*

In this passage of Scripture we are introduced to a personality trait of Jesus which is rarely seen in Scripture. As He enters the synagogue Jesus is confronted with a group of people who are making their living selling wares of worship. The Scripture makes us aware that Jesus was a regular at the Synagogue. Luke 4:14-16 (NKJV) ***"Then Jesus returned in the power of the Spirit to Galilee, and news of Him went out through all the surrounding region.15 And He taught in their synagogues, being glorified by all. 16 So He came to Nazareth, where He***

***had been brought up. And as**
His custom was, He went into
the synagogue on the Sabbath
day, and stood up to read.”*

Jesus had a habit of church attendance and if we desire to be like Him we should develop a similar habit.

The point here is that Jesus has no doubt been to this same synagogue on many occasions and witnessed the abuse of worshippers, but this time is different. We are allowed to peer just momentarily into the side of the personality of Jesus which allows Him to become angry enough to drive the money changers from the place

of worship. (If we do not accept mercy, we will eventually get judgment)

When He drives the money changers from the place of worship He makes a statement which we seldom hear but would do well to study if we hope to be the kind of church Jesus would be impressed with. At CT we are not seeking the accolades of men but the approval of the heavenly Father.

I want us to look at the statements of Jesus in this passage of Scripture and make

an attempt to discover how it might look in this modern time.

The word translated “***Prayer***” here comes from the Greek word “***Proseuche***” (pros-yoo-khay’) and means “*A place set apart or suited for the offering of prayer and worship.*” If a synagogue was not accessible and the Jews prayed and worshipped in the countryside the chosen place for prayer and worship would always be selected near a creek or stream because they would wash themselves prior to prayer and worship. This act was an act of purifying themselves to come into the presence of Jehovah.

The word translated “***Thieves***” here comes from the Greek word “***Lestes***” (lace-tace’) and means “*A place which has been plundered or taken advantage of.*”

Jesus is saying the church will either be a “***Den of thieves***” or a “***House of prayer.***” I want us to take a look at what a “***Den of thieves***” or a “***House of prayer***” might look like in 2007...

Keep in mind, the church you attend will be what we make it!

If we make it...

A den of thieves it will be
angry, abrasive, full of
antinomy, and will hold people
at arms length!

If we make it a house of prayer
it will be ample, articulate,
ambulatory, abnormal, and an
antidepressant for its
community. It will be ready to
take care of a need for anyone,
at any place and at anytime!

If we make it a den of thieves it
will be bitter, backslidden,
bizarre, brutal, blind,
bemoaning all of its troubles. It
will betray its beliefs, bar

certain kinds of people; it will bend and then break. It will have money like a bank and will balk when it comes to outreach!

If we make it a house of prayer it will be balanced, benevolent, and will batter the kingdom of darkness, booty trapping the devil and have a baptistery that actually gets used for something besides storage. It will believe the Word of God, be baptized in the Holy Ghost, blossom like a rose, and have a clear view of Beulah land!

If we make it a den of thieves it will be cold, calloused, careless, contrary, comfortable, contented, confined, comatose, and cater to a carnal crowd. It will be ceremonial; full of calamity and will cannibalizes the saints. It will continue the process of collapsing and will eventually cease!

If we make it a house of prayer it will be called, capable, calculated, cognizant, committed, compassionate, consecrated, cooperative, competent, consistent, conquering, creative, colossal, charismatic, will capitalize on

the mistakes the devil makes. It will have conviction in its singing preaching and praying, and no matter how much mud gets slung in its direction it will never cease!

If we make it a den of thieves it will be dead, dry, deceived, depressed, defiled, divided, distracted, decrepit, deformed, declining, demoralized, dirty and in a constant state of denial! It will have a depth deficiency, derelict in its duties and depending on detours to distract its followers. Worst of all, it will aid and abet those

who choose to dodge the draft
in the army of God!

If we make it a house of prayer
it will be determined,
developed, devoted and
distinctive! It will be diverse
and will dawn a different
dialect! It will disturb those
who are at ease in Zion, drive
demons delirious, doom the
devil, and will one day dock
safely at home!

If we make it a den of thieves it
will be empty, egotistical,
eccentric, encumbered, expose,
extreme, exclusive and endorse
an intoxicated lifestyle! It will

be full of excess, elude revival
and embark on a path of death!
It will be ruled by the traditions
of the elders, embarrassed to be
named among the invisible
Church and attempt to build its
own little empire here! Worst
of all, it will impose an
embargo on sending people into
the Ministry!

If we make it a house of prayer
it will be embattled, eager,
elect, earnest, established,
evangelistic, enlightened,
energized, efficient, elevated,
embellished, effectual,
empowered, endowed,
expectant, exuberant, ecstatic

and possess a tremendous ability to demonstrate its elasticity! It will embalm spiritually dead bodies with a solution that brings them back to life allowing the embers of the Holy Spirit to start a fire that the fire department from hell can't put out! It will be the epicenter of the glory of God in the earth, stand on the edge of eternity and take sinful humankind with one hand and a forgiving God with the other hand and bring the two together! It will be heaven on earth and will be ejected from this sphere to go sweeping through the pearly gates!

If we make it a den of thieves it
will be fashionable, frivolous,
fretful, frustrated, far gone, far
fetched, fussy, full of factions,
filled with fatalism, and filled
with failure!

If we make it a house of prayer
it will be fair, factual, faithful,
free, fundamental, family
oriented, fervent, full-fledged,
fanatical, futuristic, farsighted,
far-flung, full of fellowship, full
of faith, and fully furnished for
good works!

If we make it a den of thieves it
will be generic, glamorous,

gluttonous, groggy, gloomy,
guilty, grim, always got a
gimmick and the Christian life
becomes nothing more than a
game!

If we make it a house of prayer
it will be generous, genuine,
gentle, glad, going, growing,
good-hearted, grateful, and
grandiose! It will be a church
which will get the garbage out,
become goal oriented, gather
the golden grain of the last day
harvest for the glory of God,
and will gain the prize at the
end of the race!

If we make it a den of thieves it
will be half-cocked, half-
hearted, hard-hearted,
hamstrung, halting, hampered,
haphazard, hasty, haughty, and
hateful! It will be handicapped,
hesitant, hurt, hysterical,
constantly involved in half
truths, hung up on heresies, and
hobbling through life holding to
a crutch of worldliness! It will
have more hang-ups than hand-
bells and will believe that a
homosexual tendency can be
turned into an alternate lifestyle
that will be approved by God!

If we make it a house of prayer
it will be hearty, healthy,

honorable, holy, heroic and
heterosexual! It will homestead
on the ground of holiness,
becomes the habitation of God,
heirs to promise, headed to
heaven, and possesses hope
which is the anchor of the soul!
Bill Clinton is not the only one
who believes in a place called
Hope!

If we make it a den of thieves it
will be intolerant, imbalanced,
indifferent, immobile, impotent,
incompetent, indulgent,
intoxicated, infirmed,
insensitive, introverted and ill-
mannered! It will be impatient,
idolatrous, idle, ignorant,

impersonal, intoxicated with
this world, and so intellectual
that professing themselves to be
wise they become fools!

If we make it a house of prayer
it will be inspirational,
inclusive, imposing, increasing,
indigenous and informed! It
will itch to insulate the world
from judgment and believe in
baptism by immersion! Its
work will be immeasurable, it
will be identified by the
illumination that it attempts to
interject into this world and it
will take its instructions from
the great I am!

If we make it a den of thieves it
will be juvenile, lack judgment,
continuously under the juniper
tree, constantly jumping to
conclusions, and a joke in the
eyes of the world!

If we make it a house of prayer
it will be joyful, jubilant and
justified in the sight of God!

If we make it a den of thieves it
will be known for its love of the
world, and the kiss of death to
its adherents!

If we make it a house of prayer
it will be kind, knowledgeable
and a key to reaching a world

on their way to hell! It will be
the kiss of life to those who are
spiritually dead and a kiss of
peace to those who have been
tossed to and fro on life's angry
sea! It will have a close kinship
with the spirits of just men
made perfect!

If we make it a den of thieves it
will be lazy, legalistic, limited,
loving leisure, liberal, lustful, in
limbo, lapsing into lethargy, the
living dead, large in its own
eyes but little in God's eyes!

If we make it a house of prayer
it will be loving, legitimate,
lasting, loyal, labeled as
lunatics and laboring for the

Lord who loves it! It will be a
life support system for those
who have already been counted
out, lightening the loads of the
heavy laden, launching laymen
into ministry, believe in the
laying on of hands and will be
learning the language of
heaven!

If we make it a den of thieves it
will be mainstream, modern,
moderate, manipulative,
mercenary, marginal, misled,
mixed up, melancholy,
melodramatic and always
marching on middle ground! It
will be mincing words,
masquerading as the true

Church, and mimicking a
morgue!

If we make it a house of prayer
it will be marked, merciful,
mighty, militant, magnificent,
meritorious, magnetic and very
matter-of-fact! It will be
maligned, misunderstood and
misused! It will be motivated,
multiplying, have a made up
mind and manifesting miracles!
It will magnify the Messiah and
make the devil mad! It will
have a magnanimous message
to preach, moving in the
manifestation of the gifts of the
spirit and marching to the beat
of a different drummer!

If we make it a den of thieves it
will be napping, negligent,
needy, nervous, neutral, non-
cooperative and always nagging
about nothing!

If we make it a house of prayer
it will be nice, noble, noisy,
nailed to the cross with Christ,
neutralizing the nature of sin
and negating the nights in the
lives of its adherents!

If we make it a den of thieves it
will be obtuse, obsessive,
obstinate, opinionated,
ostentatious, out-manned, out-
gunned, out-smarted,

overcharged with surfeiting, out of the will of God and fulfilling the great omission!

If we make it a house of prayer it will be orderly, organized, outfitted, open-hearted, opportunistic and on target! It will open options and providing opportunities for the underprivileged! It will be in the business of operating an outlet for over-comers and operating under an oath to fulfill the great commission!

If we make it a den of thieves it will be paganistic, proud, poison, passive, permissive,

political, popular and suffering
from paralysis! It will be
promiscuous, perverse,
provocative, pretending and
pathetic! It will be a pawn in
the hands of the devil,
prejudiced and panic stricken
on judgment day!

If we make it a house of prayer
it will set the pace whiled being
personal! It will be patient,
positive, pure, potent, powerful,
productive and peaceful! It will
be Pentecostal, prophetic and
partakers of the divine nature!
It will be pregnant with a
passion for souls, poised to
preach the promises of GOD

and the perils of pretentious living! It will provide a panorama of paradise and will propel its patrons through the pearly gates!

If we make it a den of thieves it will be quiet, questionable, quarreling, and constantly in a quandary! It will be continuously quenching the spirit, conveniently caught in the quagmire of sin and always on the verge of quitting!

If we make it a house of prayer it will be quaint, quality, qualified, quantitative and will be quick to quiet all quarrels!

If we make it a den of thieves it will be racial, rabid, rotten, repetitious, redundant, reserved and repulsive! It will resist the things of GOD, always railing against that which is right and rambling about without reason!

If we make it a house of prayer it will be repentant, reconciled, refined, ransomed, right, redeemed, refreshed, rested, relaxed, respectful and responsive! It will be radiant, rejoicing, red-hot, radical and revolutionary! It will be rooted and grounded in the Word, resilient, running the race with

patience, raining on the devils
parade and reaping the rewards
of the redeemer!

If we make it a den of thieves it
will be sad, shallow,
superficial, slick, sarcastic,
skeptical and stingy! It will be
shrewd, full of scoffers,
scandalized, sick, sinful,
slumbering and always
sidestepping responsibility! It
will attempt to socialize the
gospel and becoming silent on
the issues which make an
eternal difference!

If we make it a house of prayer
it will be sacred, sovereign,

sanctified, sensible and savvy!
It will be scrutinized, stable,
settled and shutting down self-
destruction! It will be
sympathetic, seeing the
importance of Christ, staying
sick of the status quo, and
smashing the kingdom of
darkness to smithereens!

If we make it a den of thieves it
will be tantalizing, too tolerant,
toxic, treacherous, temporal,
tense, tormented, tightfisted,
thirsty and full of talebearers!
It will be tainting theological
truths, becomes a threat to it's
adherents, trading truth for
transgression and will

eventually be terminated by
GOD himself!

If we make it a house of prayer
it will be teachable, timely,
turned around, tuned in, trusting
in the trinity and tarrying for
Pentecostal power! It will be
touched by the hand of GOD,
telling the truth, triumphing in
truth, transported by triumph,
transacting treaties and
terminating the tears of those
who are hurting!

If we make it a den of thieves it
will be unhappy, uncaring,
unfeeling, unconcerned and
unconscious! It will be unkind,

untaught, unwise, unbiblical
and unclean! It will be unaware
of the sin that is around it,
attempting to be undercover,
and unable to correct the
problems of its society!
If we make it a house of prayer
it will be unshakeable,
unparalleled, under siege,
undefeated, unbreakable,
upright, unique, unified and
universal! It will umpire
ultimatums, underwrite unction
and unveiling the unknown!

If we make it a den of thieves it
will be vain, vagrant, vengeful,
vicious, vulnerable, and create a

vacuum in the lives of its adherents!

If we make it a house of prayer it will be valuable, victorious, virtuous, vital and visionary! It will be high voltage, vacating vices and creating viable vessels!

If we make it a den of thieves it will be wasted, watered down, worldly, wild, whipped and always waffling on the issues! It will learn to live with spiritual wantonness and will eventually wail in outer darkness!

If we make it a house of prayer
it will be whole, wise, walking
the walk, awakening the weary,
reaching wretches and willing
to work for wages! It will set
some high water marks,
weather the storm and waiting
on a wedding!

If we make it a den of thieves it
will be eccentric and eventually
excommunicated from the
invisible Church!

If we make it a house of prayer
it will be excited, exemplifying
a good example, prescribing
extra patience and introducing
x-sinners to Christ! It will

make the expense of living for
GOD affordable!

If we make it a den of thieves it
will constantly be yakking
about things that it does not
understand and yawning
because of its comatose
condition! Without knowing
what it is craving it will yearn
for the things of GOD!

If we make it a house of prayer
it will yield a yoke that is
bearable!

If we make it a den of thieves it
will produce a zest for life that
is wrongly directed!

If we make it a house of prayer
it will zero us in on proper zeal,
anticipating spiritual Zion, and
end up experiencing zero
gravity!